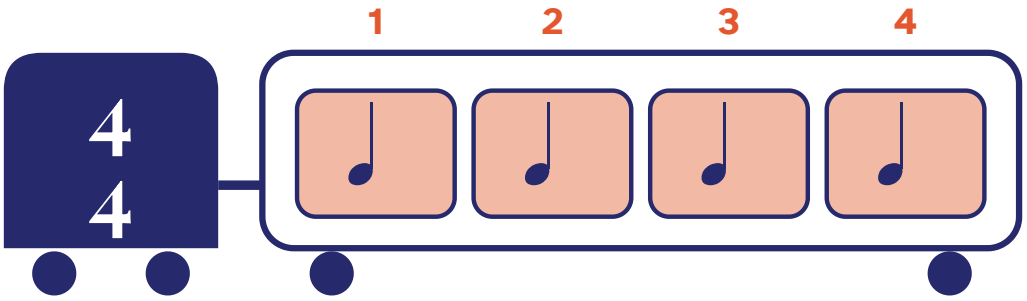
PART II · TIME · 4

Time signatures

Two numbers, like a train ticket: the **top number** says how many seats (counts) each bar has; the **bottom number** says which note fills one seat.

THE SECRET
Top number: how many beats. Bottom number: which note gets one beat.



Top: how many seats · bottom: which note sits in one

The bottom number

BOTTOM	NOTE	ONE COUNT IS A	FIRST MET
2	𝅗𝅥	minim	Level 3
4	♩	crotchet	Level 0
8	♪	quaver	Level 1
16	𝅘𝅥𝅯	semiquaver	*Extra*

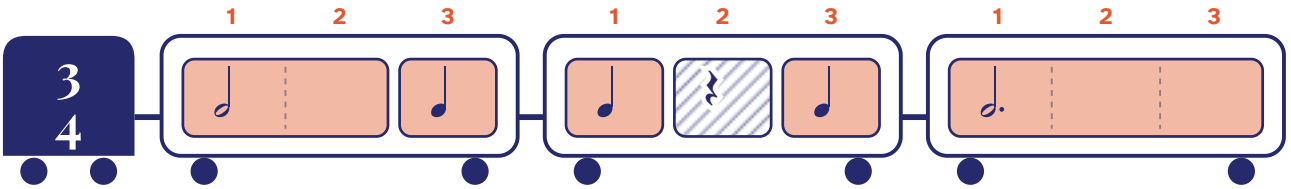
Simple time: each beat divides in two

TIME SIGNATURE	EACH BAR HOLDS	FIRST MET
2/4	2 crotchets	Level 0
3/4	3 crotchets	Level 0
4/4 𝄴	4 crotchets (the C sign: common time)	Level 0
2/2 𝄵	2 minims (the cut C: cut common time)	Level 3
3/2	3 minims	Level 3
4/2	4 minims	*Extra*
3/8	3 quavers	Level 3

PART II · TIME · 4 · CONTINUED

Think of a train

In 3/4 every carriage (bar) has exactly **3 seats**; each seat is one crotchet beat. Notes book seats: a minim takes 2, a crotchet 1. A rest books a seat and leaves it **empty** (shaded). Every seat in every carriage must be booked.



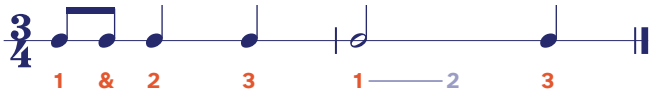
minim + crotchet · crotchet, crotchet rest, crotchet · dotted minim: 3 seats each

Changing time signature

A new time signature can appear in the middle of a piece, right after a bar line; it holds until the next one. A time signature is written only once, not on every line.

EXAMPLE 1

Read a time signature



1. **Top number 3:** three counts in each bar.
2. **Bottom number 4:** a crotchet is one count.
3. **Check a bar:** two quavers + crotchet + crotchet = 3.

3/4: **three crotchet beats** in every bar.

GAME

Which ticket?

1	2	3	4
3 crotchets	4 crotchets	6 quavers	2 minims

Each bar holds these notes. Write its time signature.

Answer: 1 3/4 · 2 4/4 · 3 6/8 · 4 2/2 (or 4/4).

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

4
4

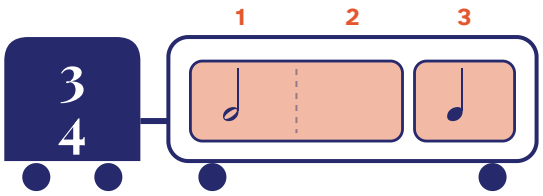
Open a piece you are playing.

Find the time signature, then count the seats in bar 1: do the notes add up to the top number? Try bar 2 as well.

PART II · TIME · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Count a bar of 3/4

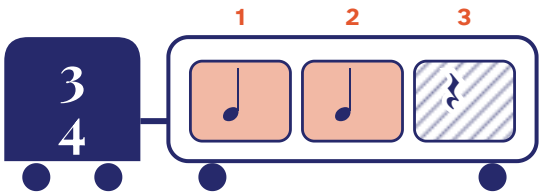


1. **The top number is 3:** three seats in every bar.
2. **The minim** books seats 1 and 2: say "1 2" while it sounds.
3. **The crotchet** takes seat 3.

Count **1 2 3**, and hold the minim through 2.

EXAMPLE 3

Where does the rest go?
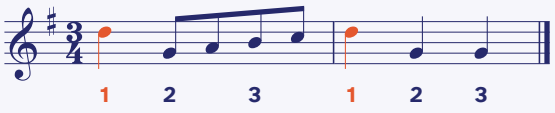


1. **Three seats** in 3/4.
2. **Two crotchets** fill seats 1 and 2.
3. **The rest** books seat 3: count it, do not skip it.

Rests book seats too: **1 2 (3)**.

YOU KNOW THIS

Minuet in G (from the Notebook for Anna Magdalena Bach)



Every bar holds **three crotchet beats**: 1 2 3, 1 2 3, the step of the dance. That is 3/4.

Try it. Count 1 2 3 aloud while someone plays it.

TRAP

- × Reading the bottom number as a count: it names the note that gets one beat.
- × Reading 6/8 as six beats: at most speeds it moves in two.
- × Mixing up 3/4 and 6/8: both hold six quavers, grouped differently (p. 52).

SEE ALSO

Pulse and the bar p. 39 · Compound time p. 52

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Level 0 · Time signatures · Online: Library › Time signatures